

KATE BARNES, Ph.D.

Email: katebarnes@tamu.edu

Website: kate-barnes.com

Pronouns: She/Her

Updated: February, 2026

ACADEMIC POSTITIONS

Texas A&M University

Postdoctoral Research Associate

Education Research Center (ERC)

College of Education and Human Development

College Station, TX

July 2025 – Present

- Conduct quantitative analyses using state longitudinal data to evaluate educator preparation programs and communicate findings to state stakeholders, while continuing an active personal research agenda on school calendar reform through peer-reviewed publications and national conference presentations.
- Led applied policy research on key education issues in Texas by identifying school district needs, supporting grant writing, and developing research questions aligned with current state policy debates.
- Coordinate stakeholder engagement within the university and with external partners through ongoing collaborations, a bi-weekly newsletter, and events managed from planning to execution.
- Support graduate student development through structured mentorship, ongoing feedback, professional guidance, and coordination of student-focused initiatives.

EDUCATION

University of Arkansas

Doctor of Philosophy

Education Policy

Dissertation Title: *Rewriting the School Calendar: A Mixed-Methods Analysis of Four-Day School Week Implementation in Arkansas*

Fayetteville, AR

May 2025

Arkansas State University

Master of Science in Education

Educational Leadership

Concentration: Curriculum and Design

Jonesboro, AR

August 2019

University of Tennessee, Knoxville

Bachelor of the Arts

Major: Interdisciplinary Studies: Sustainability

Minor: Environmental Studies

Knoxville, TN

May 2014

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

University of Arkansas

Graduate Research Assistant, Department of Education Reform

Fayetteville, AR

August 2021 – May 2025

- Collaborating with EDRE's Office for Education Policy to organize and implement researcher projects with Arkansas public schools focusing on:
 - Impacts of adopting a four-day school week
 - Identifying the early predictors of students placed in alternative learning environments
 - Various structural school models or educational paths available to students
- Communicate research findings to diverse stakeholders, including educators, policymakers, and community members, through presentations, reports, and other media

Northwest Arkansas Education Service Cooperative

Strategic Data Fellow, Office for Education Policy

Fayetteville, AR

June 2024 – May 2025

- Collaborate school district leadership to conduct research for and with member schools of the NWA Educational Service Cooperative
- Create tailored reports for districts highlighting growth, achievement, and programmatic outcomes, with breakdowns by school buildings
- Develop clear visualizations and user-friendly reports to communicate key metrics to district stakeholders

To&Through Project, UChicago Consortium on School Research

Data and Research Intern

Chicago, IL

June 2023 – September 2023

- Categorized elementary schools by school type in alignment with high school types for analysis, helping policymakers understand how to best prepare students for success
- Collaborated with educators, policymakers, and communities to provide actionable data on student attainment and lead conversations to help them make meaning and take action
- Participated in peer coding reviews and working groups to develop skills in R and Git

PUBLICATIONS

PEER REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

Barnes, K., (*In Revision*). Is Reducing the Week Reducing Teacher Burnout? An Analysis of Teacher Well-Being in Four-Day Districts. *Educational Researcher*.

Barnes, K., & McKenzie, S. C. (2025). We Wanted to Do Something Innovative: Exploring Motivations of Arkansas Districts Adopting Four-Day School Weeks or Year-Round Calendars. *Leaderships and Policy in Schools*, 1-15.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/15700763.2025.2491438>

WORKING PAPERS & RESEARCH BRIEFS

Barnes, K., & McKenzie, S. (2025). Four-Day School Week Across State Lines: Insights on Attendance from Missouri and Arkansas. [Education Report](#). PRiME Center, St. Louis University

Barnes, K., & McKenzie, S. (2024). Professional Learning Communities and Student Outcomes: A Quantitative Analysis of the PLC at Work Model in Arkansas Schools. [Arkansas Education Report](#). Office for Education Policy, University of Arkansas.

Barnes, K., & McKenzie, S. (2023). Exploring Academic Outcomes in Arkansas Schools: A Study of Four-Day School Week and Year-Round Calendar Districts. [Arkansas Education Report](#). Office for Education Policy, University of Arkansas.

Djita, R., **Barnes, K.,** McKenzie, S. (2023). English Language Learners and Their Postsecondary Education Outcomes: Evidence from Arkansas. [Working Paper](#). Department of Education Reform, University of Arkansas.

Barnes, K., & McKenzie, S. (2023). We Wanted to Do Something Innovative: Exploring Motivations of Arkansas Districts Adopting Four-Day School Weeks or Year-Round Calendars. [Arkansas Education Report](#). Office for Education Policy, University of Arkansas.

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S., and Reid, C. (2022). Movin' On Up: An Examination of Value-Added Growth During School Transition Years in Arkansas. [Arkansas Education Report](#).

POLICY REPORTS

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2024). Effects of PLC at Work in Arkansas on Student Outcomes (Policy Brief). [OEP Policy Brief](#).

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2023). Exploring Academic Outcomes in Arkansas Schools: A Study of Four-Day School Week and Year-Round Calendar Districts (Policy Brief). [OEP Policy Brief](#).

McGee, J., **Barnes, K.** (2023). Analysis of Arkansas's Career and Technical Education (CTE) Programs (Arkansas LEARNS Report 4A). [Executive Order Report](#).

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2023). Explorations of Motivations for Adopting a Four-Day School Week or Year-Round Calendar: Evidence from Arkansas (Policy Brief). [OEP Policy Brief](#).

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2022). An Examination of School Transitions on Value-Added Growth in Arkansas (Policy Brief). [OEP Policy Brief](#).

OTHER PUBLICATIONS

Barnes, K. (2023, April 27). [Bold or Risky? Caution on Changing School Calendar](#): [Op-Ed]. Arkansas Democrat Gazette.

Barnes, K. (2023, March 8). [Hot Topic: School Calendars](#). Blog – Office for Education Policy.

Barnes, K. (2022, April 6). [Building Transitions Lead to Lower Value-Added Growth for Middle-School Students](#). Blog – Office for Education Policy.

PRESENTATIONS

Barnes, K. (2026). Holding Time Constant: Four-Day School Weeks and Student Achievement in Arkansas. Paper Presentation. Presented at the Annual Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP) Conference, Chicago, IL, March 21, 2026

Barnes, K. (2025). Does Reducing the Week Reduce Teacher Burnout? An Analysis of Teacher Well-Being in Four-Day Districts. Paper Presentation. Presented at the MidSouth Education Policy Workshop, University of Kentucky, Lexington, KY, October 17, 2025.

Barnes, K. (2025). Assessing Teacher Burnout: A Comparative Study of Traditional and Four-Day School Week Districts. Paper Presentation. Presented at the Annual Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP) Conference, Washington D.C., March 15, 2025

Barnes, K. (2025). Professional Learning Communities and Student Outcomes: A Quantitative Analysis of the PLC at Work Model. Paper Presentation. Presented at the Annual Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP) Conference, Washington D.C., March 13, 2025

Barnes, K. (2024). Four-Day School Week in Arkansas: What We Know So Far. Panel Presentation. Presented at LEARNing Full Speed Ahead: What Progress Have We Made So Far Conference, Little Rock, AR, December 11, 2024.

Barnes, K. (2024). Assessing Teacher Burnout: A Comparative Study of Traditional and Four-Day School Week Districts. Paper Presentation. Presented at Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (APPAM) Fall Research Conference, National Harbor, Maryland, November 21, 2024.

Barnes, K., Chabra, P., Medler, A., Molloy, M., Wallace, M. (2024). RPP Insights from Early Career and Student Scholars. Panel Presentation. Presented at National Network of Education Research Practice Partnerships (NNERPP) Annual Forum, Richmond, VA, July 25, 2024.

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2024). We Wanted to Do Something Innovative: Exploring Motivations of Arkansas Districts Adopting Four-Day School Weeks or Year-Round Calendars. Paper Presentation. Presented at the American Educational Research Association (AERA) Conference, Philadelphia, PA, April 11, 2024.

Barnes, K., (2024). Exploring the Impact of Four-Day School Weeks on Educational Choice and Access: A Quantitative Analysis in Arkansas. Paper Presentation. Presented at the International School Choice and Reform (ISCRC) Conference, Madrid, Spain, January 7, 2024.

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2023). We Wanted to Do Something Innovative: Exploring Motivations of Arkansas Districts Adopting Four-Day School Weeks or Year-Round Calendars. Paper Presentation. Presented at the Annual Mid-South Educational Research Associates (MSERA) Conference, Pensacola, FL, November 10, 2023.

Djita, R., **Barnes, K.,** McKenzie, S. (2023). English Language Learners and their Post Secondary Education Outcomes: Evidence from Arkansas. Roundtable Presentation. Presented at the American Educational Research Association (AERA) Conference, Chicago, IL, April 14, 2023.

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2023). Impacts of Categorical Funding Policies on Alternative School Placements. Paper Presentation. Paper Presentation. Presented at the Annual Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP) Conference, Denver, CO, March 23, 2023.

Djita, R., **Barnes, K.,** McKenzie, S. (2022). English Language Learners and their Post Secondary Education Outcomes: Evidence from Arkansas. Paper Presentation. Presented at the Annual Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP) Conference, Denver, CO, March 23, 2023.

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2023) We Wanted to Do Something Innovative: Exploring Motivations of Arkansas Districts Adopting Four-Day School Weeks or Year-Round Calendars. Paper Presentation. Presented at Moving Arkansas Education Forward Conference, Little Rock, AR, February 16, 2023.

Barnes, K., McKenzie, S. (2022). Understanding the Early Predictors for Alternative School Placement: Evidence from Arkansas. Paper Presentation. Presented at the annual Mid-South Educational Research Associates (MSERA) Conference, Little Rock, AR, November 10, 2022.

Djita, R., **Barnes, K.,** McKenzie, S. (2022). English Language Learners and their Post Secondary Education Outcomes: Evidence from Arkansas. Presented at the Annual Mid-South Educational Research Associates (MSERA) Conference, Little Rock, AR, November 9, 2022.

Barnes, K. (2022). Movin' On Up: An Examination of Value-Added Growth During School Transition Years in Arkansas. Paper Presentation. Presented at the Arkansas Department of Education Summit, Hot Springs, AR, July 12, 2022.

Barnes, K. (2022). Predictors for Entering an Alternative Learning Environment in Arkansas. Poster Presentation. Presented at the Annual Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP) Conference, Denver, CO, March 17, 2022.

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

Barnes, K, McKenzie, S. (2023) We Wanted to Do Something Innovative: Exploring Motivations of Arkansas Districts Adopting Four-Day School Weeks or Year-Round Calendars. Poster Presentation. Four-Day School Week Conference, Corvallis, OR, October 20, 2023.

MISCELLANEOUS

RADIO INTERVIEWS

Moore, M. (Reporter). (2025, April 8). [A bill in the Arkansas Legislature threatens the future of the four-day school weeks](#). In *Ozarks at Large*. KUAF, National Public Radio.

Moore, M. (Reporter). (2024, June 27). [No statistically significant results” from Solution Tree’s program according to recent study](#). In *Ozarks at Large*. KUAF, National Public Radio.

Travis, J. (Reporter). (2023, November 22). [Lincoln Consolidated School District trims school week to benefit mental health](#). In *Ozarks at Large*. KUAF, National Public Radio.

Kellams, K. (Director). (2023, March 3). [Why Schools Consider Four-Day Weeks](#). In *Ozarks at Large*. KUAF, National Public Radio.

PRESS MENTIONS

McKinnon, E. (2025, May 17). [Smaller districts see some benefit of shorter weeks](#). *Arkansas Democrat Gazette*.

Snyder, J. (2024a, May 25). [Report on 7-year Arkansas education contract finds no significant gains; state considering \\$99.4M renewal](#). *Arkansas Democrat Gazette*.

Hardy, B. (2024, June 3). [Education vendor Solution Tree abandons ship on hefty state contract](#). *Arkansas Times*.

Snyder, J. (2024b, June 3). [Solution Tree CEO requests that Arkansas Department of Education withdraw proposed contract from state’s review process](#). *Arkansas Democrat Gazette*.

HONORS & AWARDS

Outstanding Doctoral Student, UARK College of Education & Health Profession	2025
Emerging Education Policy Scholars (EEPS), Thomas B. Fordham Institute	2025
James E. McLean Distinguished Research Paper Award, MSERA	2023

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

University of Arkansas Doctoral Academy Fellowship	2021 - 2025
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ACADEMIC SERVICE

Brownbag Lecture Coordinator, EDRE	2024 – 2025
Lecture Series Coordinator, EDRE	2022 – 2024
Graduate and Professional Student Congress	2021 – 2022

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)	2021 - Present
Mid-South Educational Research Association (MSERA)	2022 - Present
American Educational Research Association (AERA)	2023 - Present
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (APPAM)	2024 - Present

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

TEACHING ASSISTANT

Quantitative Analytical Techniques for Education Policy	Fall 2023
PhD in Education Policy, University of Arkansas	
Research Seminar in Education Policy	Spring 2023, Spring 2024
PhD in Education Policy, University of Arkansas	

K-12 TEACHING

Owl Creek School	Fayetteville, AR
<i>5th and 6th Grade Teacher, Science and Mathematics</i>	August 2017 – May 2021
Decatur Middle School	Decatur, AR
<i>5th Grade Teacher, Science and Mathematics</i>	August 2016 – May 2017

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Ozark Natural Science Center	Huntsville, AR
<i>Teacher Naturalist</i>	August 2015 – May 2016
City of Fayetteville	Fayetteville, AR
<i>AmeriCorps Volunteer, Recycling & Trash Collection</i>	October 2014 – August 2015